Captain's Guide

companion page for the Allergen Flags

Flags are Should-Have-Thought-Of-It technology: a sticker that says what's actually inside the dish, attached at the moment of cooking by the person who actually knows. Tape one page of flags to the cooler and one to the fridge, and most volunteer mistakes become impossible.

Set the expectations honestly

— A flag is a note from a home kitchen, not a factory certification. "Contains dairy" is solid ground; "no gluten anywhere" is hope. Stick to the contains-side of the truth.

— For anyone with a severe allergy, the family decides what comes in the door. Volunteers offer; the family chooses. Say this out loud to volunteers so nobody feels policed or rejected.

— Sauces, broths, and spice mixes are where hidden allergens live. Ask volunteers to check those three jars before they call a dish "safe."

Making the flags effortless

— Pre-cut everything. Scissors on demand is a real barrier at 6 a.m.

— The blank "contains _____" badges exist for whatever this particular family is avoiding that isn't a classic allergen — mint, melon, frankfurters, you name it. Handwrite those in.

— The "this one's easy / nothing serious" badge is not decoration: it tells the family they can relax for one dinner without reading fine print. That dinner is often the favorite.

Gentle gotchas

— Cross-contamination lives on boards, knives, and pans. Volunteers with allergy-flagged homes know this; volunteers who don't, get one polite line from you about clean pans.

— Spice is an allergen too, emotionally. Mild-by-default wins more families than it disappoints.

Nobody talks about the anxiety of wondering what's in a neighbor's casserole: the flags do that worrying instead, all before the first bite. That's what a thoughtful system does — it carries dread so people don't have to.